

What else to watch: *Peeping Tom* (1960, p.334) ■ *Eraserhead* (1977, p.338) ■ *Lost Highway* (1997) ■ *Mulholland Dr.* (2001, p.342) ■ *Inland Empire* (2006)

a throwback to the noir era, although Lynch adds a very modern take on sexual deviancy and voyeurism. The repulsion we feel in witnessing Frank's perversions is amplified by Lynch's fondness for noir tropes, so that the audience is made to feel that he is corrupting something familiar to them all.

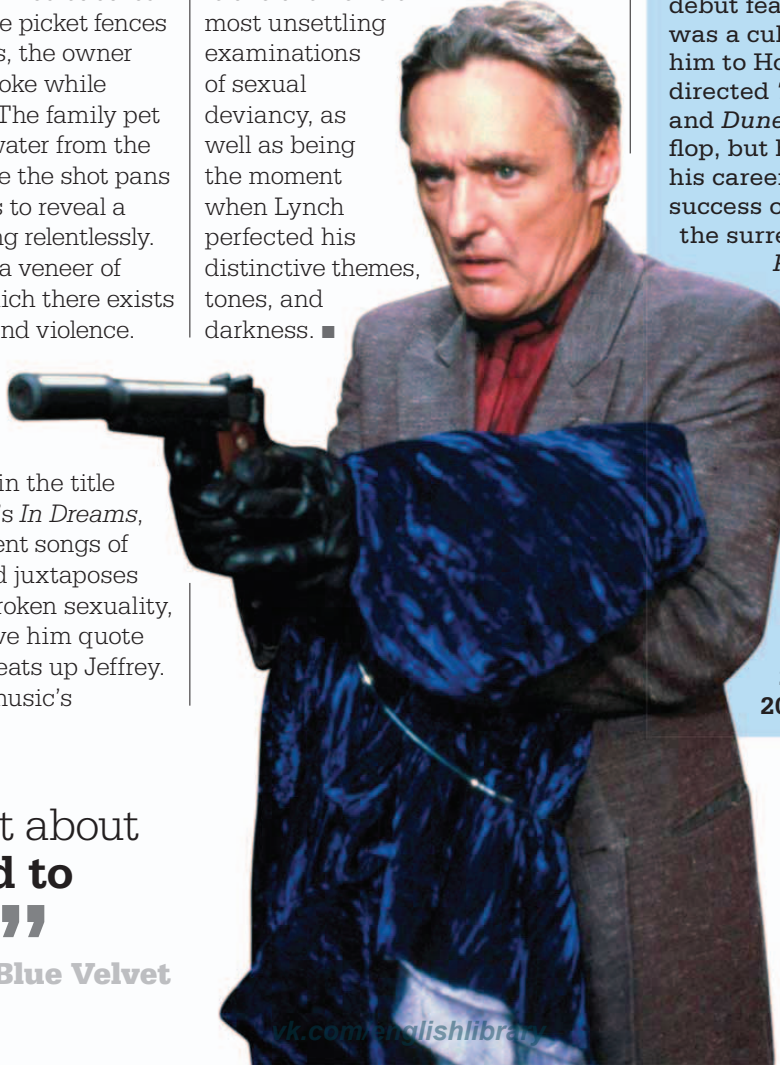
The horror beneath

One of Lynch's favorite stylistic themes is the artificiality of postwar Americana and the darkness that lies beneath it. The opening scene pans through an idealized suburban yard, with neat, white picket fences and blooming flowers, the owner of which suffers a stroke while watering his plants. The family pet rushes to drink the water from the discarded hose, while the shot pans deeper into the grass to reveal a colony of ants foraging relentlessly. The surface world is a veneer of happiness, below which there exists baseness, struggle, and violence.

This theme is continued in the director's use of music. From Bobby Vinton's *Blue Velvet* in the title track to Roy Orbison's *In Dreams*, Lynch hijacks innocent songs of romantic longing and juxtaposes them with Frank's broken sexuality, going so far as to have him quote the lyrics while he beats up Jeffrey. It's almost as if the music's

innocence is as much of a lie as the seemingly perfect front yard from the prologue.

Blue Velvet approaches horror in a new way. Its depravity derives not from guns and gore, but from sex used as a vehicle for the worst aspects of humanity. The hero, Jeffrey, is seen hiding in a closet, a voyeur peeping at Dorothy. Frank is threatening physically, but his sado-masochism is what makes him terrifying. This key moment, placing us in the closet with Jeffrey as he watches Frank rape Dorothy, is one of cinema's most unsettling examinations of sexual deviancy, as well as being the moment when Lynch perfected his distinctive themes, tones, and darkness. ■



David Lynch Director

David Lynch was born in 1946 in Missoula, Montana, a small town not dissimilar to those featured in his movies. His debut feature, *Eraserhead*, was a cult success that took him to Hollywood, where he directed *The Elephant Man* and *Dune*. The latter was a flop, but he reestablished his career with the critical success of *Blue Velvet* and the surreal TV series *Twin Peaks*. He has since followed a singular path, creating movies that could only ever have been made by him.

Key movies

1977 *Eraserhead*
1986 *Blue Velvet*
1990 *Wild at Heart*
2001 *Mulholland Dr.*
2006 *Inland Empire*

“You’ve got about one second to live buddy!”

Frank Booth / *Blue Velvet*

The blue velvet of the title is a robe that Frank forces Dorothy to wear as he rapes her. Typically for Lynch, a beautiful thing is used for a corrupt end.